

What interactive storytelling does

Report View: Guide users through the data with purpose, not just visuals



Choose the right interaction feature

### Navigate

Move users through the report

- ✓ Drill-through to detail pages
- ✓ Buttons for back and next
- ✓ Page navigators
- ✓ Bookmark navigators

### Filter and Explore

Let users control the context

- ✓ Slicers for key dimensions
- ✓ Cross-filtering between visuals
- ✓ Edit interactions to control flow
- ✓ Reset filters button

### Layer Context

Add detail without clutter

- ✓ Report tooltips on hover
- ✓ Bookmarks for guided views
- ✓ Toggles for alternate views
- ~ Use only when it adds clarity

Key questions before adding interactions

What journey should users take?

Does drill-through add value here?

Which slicers does the user need?

Do interactions confuse or clarify?

Is a reset button needed?

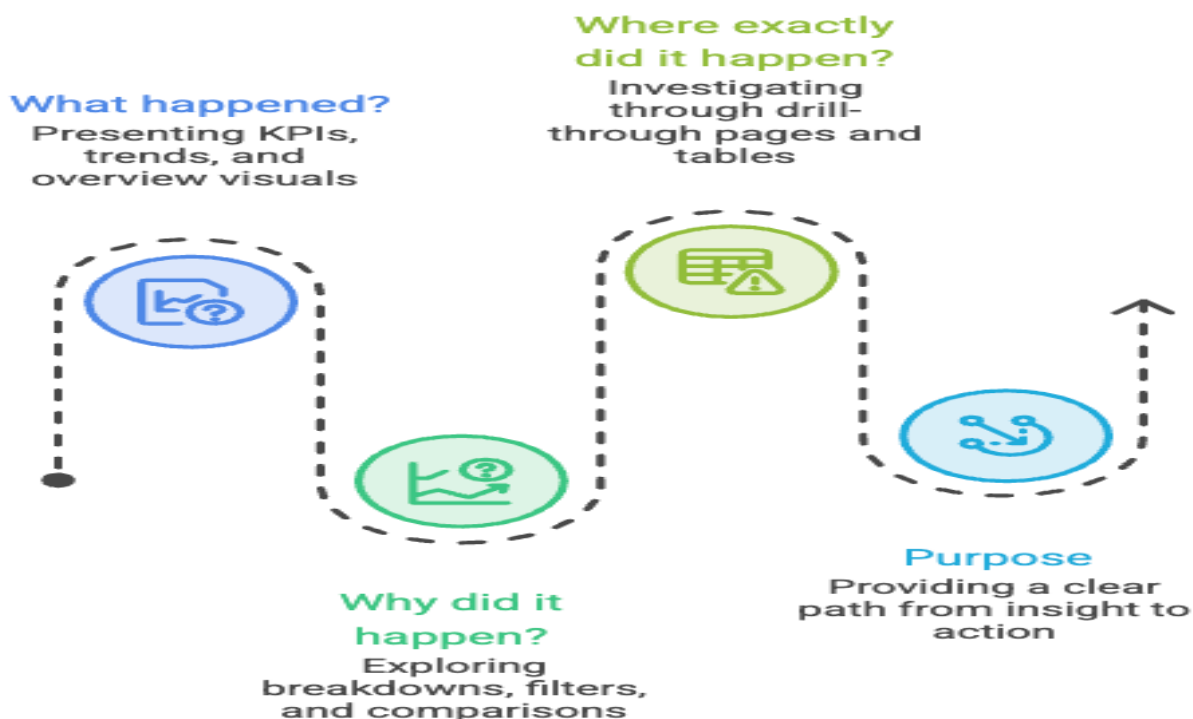
Does the tooltip add real context?

"The goal is not to make the report more clickable. The goal is to help users reach the next decision with confidence."

## Introduction: What is Interactive Storytelling?

Interactive storytelling in Power BI is the process of designing a report that guides users through the data instead of leaving them to explore randomly. A normal report may show charts, KPIs, and tables. An interactive report helps users move through a clear analytical journey. That journey usually looks like this:

### Power BI Storytelling Structure



In Power BI, interactive storytelling is created using features such as:

- Drill-through
- Report tooltips
- Bookmarks
- Buttons
- Page navigators
- Bookmark navigators
- Slicers
- Cross-filtering
- Edit interactions
- Reset filters

The goal is not to add interaction for the sake of interaction. The goal is to make the report easier to use, easier to explore, and easier to act on.

## Concepts in Brief

### 1. Drill-through

Drill-through allows users to move from a summary visual to a detailed page filtered for the selected item. **For example**, a user can right-click a platform, gender, product, region, or category and open a dedicated detail page for that selection. **Use it when:** users need to move from summary to investigation.

### 2. Report Tooltips

Report tooltips show extra information when users hover over a visual. Instead of overcrowding the page, tooltips can show supporting metrics, mini charts, or additional context. **Use it when:** users need more detail without adding more visuals to the main page.

### 3. Bookmarks

Bookmarks capture a specific report state, including filters, slicers, selected visuals, hidden visuals, and page layout. They can be used to create toggles, guided views, reset buttons, or storytelling sequences. **Use it when:** users need controlled views or a guided report experience.

### 4. Buttons

Buttons allow users to perform actions such as moving between pages, going back, applying bookmarks, resetting filters, or opening specific report views. Common button uses include Back, Reset, Next Page, Previous Page, and View Toggle. **Use it when:** users need simple and clear navigation.

### 5. Page Navigators

Page navigators automatically create navigation buttons for report pages. They make the report feel more like an app instead of relying only on page tabs. **Use it when:** the report has multiple pages and users need easy movement between them.

### 6. Bookmark Navigators

Bookmark navigators allow users to switch between bookmarked states. For example, users can toggle between a Lifestyle View and a Mental Health View on the same report page. **Use it when:** multiple views need to exist on the same page without duplicating pages.

### 7. Slicers

Slicers are visual filters that allow users to narrow the report by fields such as date, age group, gender, region, product, platform, or category. They can appear as lists, dropdowns, tiles, buttons, or date ranges. **Use it when:** users need control over the report context.

### 8. Cross-filtering

Cross-filtering happens when selecting one visual automatically filters or highlights other visuals on the page. This helps users explore relationships between categories, segments, and metrics. **Use it when:** users need to see how one selection affects the rest of the report.

## 9. Edit Interactions

Edit interactions allow analysts to control how one visual affects another visual. A selected visual can filter, highlight, or have no effect on other visuals. **Use it when:** default interactions create confusion or distract from the story.

## 10. Reset Filters

A reset button can be created using bookmarks and buttons to return the report to its default state. This is useful when users apply multiple filters and need a quick way to start again. **Use it when:** the report has many slicers or interactive elements.

# Case Study: Teen Mental Health Interactive Storytelling Report

For this week's case study, the report uses a synthetic teen mental health and social media dataset. The dataset includes information such as:

- Age
- Gender
- Social media hours
- Preferred platform
- Sleep hours
- Physical activity level
- Academic performance
- Stress level
- Anxiety level
- Depression status

The purpose of the report is to show how a wellbeing team could explore patterns between teen social media use, lifestyle habits, and mental health indicators. This dataset is synthetic and used only for educational and dashboard demonstration purposes. It should not be used for medical diagnosis, healthcare decisions, or clinical interpretation.

## Case Study Video Description

The video walkthrough demonstrates the report experience only. It does not show the step-by-step build process.

The walkthrough starts on the Executive Summary page, where users get a high-level view of the dataset through KPI cards such as total teens, depression rate, average sleep hours, average social media hours, average stress level, and average anxiety level.

It then shows how slicers can change the report context by filtering the view by gender, age group, preferred platform, and depression status. This helps users explore the data without changing the underlying dataset.

Next, the walkthrough moves to the Lifestyle Deep Dive page. This page compares lifestyle and mental health indicators such as physical activity, sleep hours, social media usage, academic performance, stress, and anxiety across depression status. The visuals help users explore possible patterns between behaviour, lifestyle, and mental health indicators.

The video also demonstrates report tooltips. When users hover over selected visuals, a small snapshot appears with supporting metrics such as depression rate and average social media hours. This adds extra context without making the main page crowded.

The walkthrough then highlights cross-filtering, where selecting a value in one visual updates related visuals on the page. This allows users to explore relationships between age groups, platform usage, sleep, social media behaviour, and mental health indicators.

Finally, the video moves to the Segment Detail page. This page acts as the detailed investigation layer, showing segment-level KPIs, platform breakdown, mental health indicators, and a detailed table of records. The back button allows users to return to the previous report page easily.

The .pbix file will be shared through GitHub so readers can download it, open the report, and explore the interactive features themselves.

Github : [Link](#)

## Practical Way to Decide



### A Simple Decision Guide for Power BI Interactivity

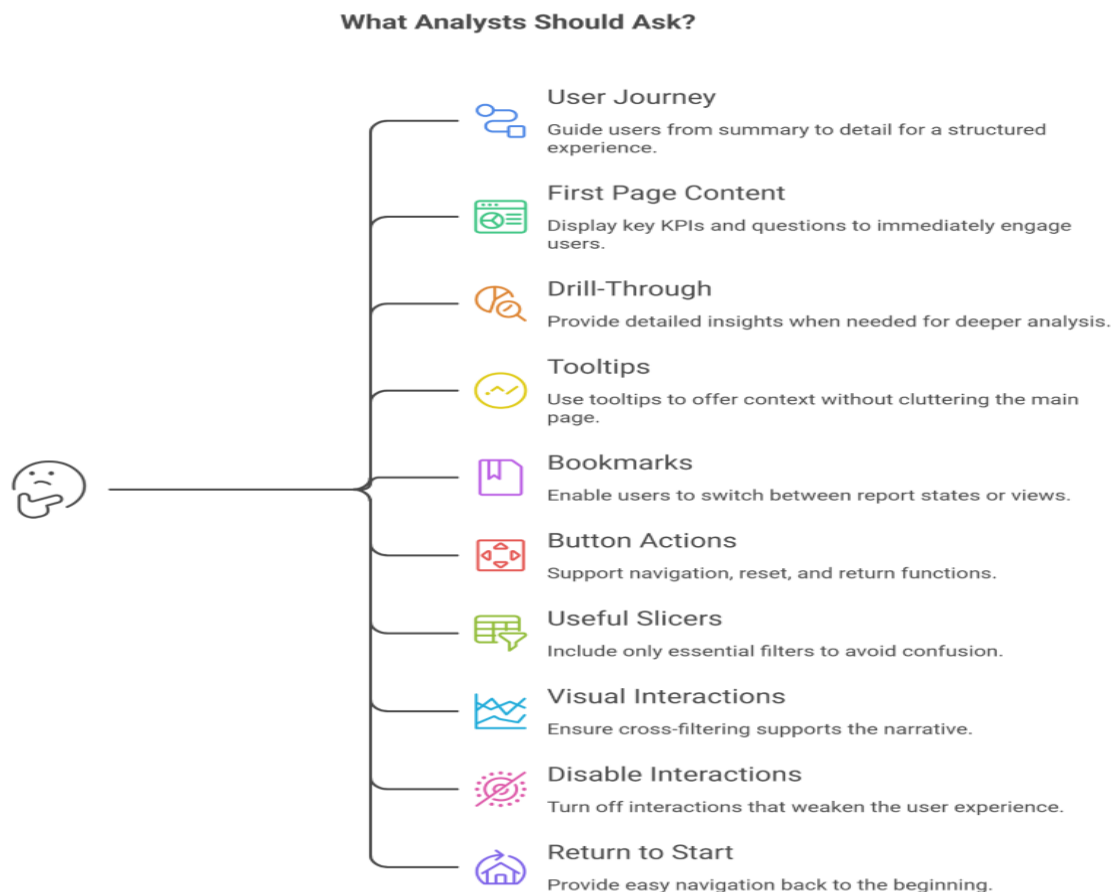
Choose the right interactive feature based on how users need to explore the report.

|                                        |  |                                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------------------|--|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>1</b><br><b>DRILL-THROUGH</b>       |  | <b>Use drill-through when:</b><br>Users need to move from a summary visual to a detailed page for a selected item.                   |
| <b>2</b><br><b>REPORT TOOLTIPS</b>     |  | <b>Use report tooltips when:</b><br>Users need extra context, but the main page should remain clean.                                 |
| <b>3</b><br><b>BOOKMARKS</b>           |  | <b>Use bookmarks when:</b><br>You need to save and reuse a specific report state, view, or layout.                                   |
| <b>4</b><br><b>BUTTONS</b>             |  | <b>Use buttons when:</b><br>Users need clear actions such as back, reset, next, previous, or view switching.                         |
| <b>5</b><br><b>PAGE NAVIGATORS</b>     |  | <b>Use page navigators when:</b><br>The report has multiple pages and users need simple navigation.                                  |
| <b>6</b><br><b>BOOKMARK NAVIGATORS</b> |  | <b>Use bookmark navigators when:</b><br>Users need to switch between different views on the same page.                               |
| <b>7</b><br><b>SLICERS</b>             |  | <b>Use slicers when:</b><br>Users need to filter the report by date, category, segment, region, platform, or other business fields.  |
| <b>8</b><br><b>CROSS-FILTERING</b>     |  | <b>Use cross-filtering when:</b><br>Selecting one visual should help users understand how the rest of the report changes.            |
| <b>9</b><br><b>EDIT INTERACTIONS</b>   |  | <b>Use edit interactions when:</b><br>Default cross-filtering creates confusion or affects visuals that should remain unchanged.     |
| <b>10</b><br><b>RESET FILTERS</b>      |  | <b>Use reset filters when:</b><br>Users may apply multiple slicers or selections and need an easy way to return to the default view. |



Interactive features help make Power BI reports easier to explore, guide, and understand.

# What Analysts Should Ask



## Conclusion

Interactive storytelling turns a Power BI report from a static collection of visuals into a guided decision-making experience. Drill-through, tooltips, bookmarks, buttons, navigators, slicers, and cross-filtering all help users move through the report with purpose.

The goal is not to make the report more clickable. The goal is to help users understand the story, explore the right details, and reach the next decision with confidence.

Stay tuned for next week's article in The Insight Stack: Power BI, Layer by Layer, where we move into Week 9: Advanced Analytics and explore how analysts use features such as Key Influencers, Decomposition Tree, Q&A, Smart Narrative, and AI visuals to explain patterns and drivers inside Power BI.

## Further Reading

- [Drillthrough in Power BI Reports: Navigate to Detailed Insights - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- [Create a numeric or date range slicer in Power BI - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- [Create and Configure Buttons in Power BI Reports - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- [Create report bookmarks in Power BI - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)
- [Create Page and Bookmark Navigators - Power BI | Microsoft Learn](#)